PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Land Rover Series I–III

1948–1985 · Series I · Series II · Series IIA · Series III

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Chassis rear crossmember and outriggers**
  These are repaired or replaced more than anything else on a Series frame. Feel along the top of the box sections and above the bump stops, where off-road loads concentrate. Heavy rot can mean a replacement chassis, which series123's guide puts at £1,000-plus in the UK, so make sure the price reflects it.
- [ ] **Bulkhead and door hinges**
  Check the lower bulkhead, the footwell corners and around the door hinges, plus anywhere the aluminium body touches steel: body-to-chassis mounts and where the wings bolt to the bulkhead. Serious bulkhead rot usually means the body has to come off.
- [ ] **Gearbox jumping out**
  First and second wear and can jump out of gear. Press and release the throttle in each gear on the test drive, try every ratio including low range, and listen for noises. The series123 guide rates the Series III gearbox as weaker than the Series II's.
- [ ] **Mismatched differentials**
  Owners sometimes fit a taller rear differential for economy. If front and rear ratios don't match, the truck will fight itself in four-wheel drive. Drive a short distance on soft ground to confirm 4WD engages and behaves.
- [ ] **Half-shafts and drive flanges**
  A clunk from the rear when you come to a stop (the 'Salisbury clunk' on later trucks) usually means worn splines in the drive flange. Rovers North forum members report flanges strip out occasionally and recommend carrying a spare. Check for play in the propshaft UJs too.
- [ ] **Springs and mounts**
  Leaves should be uniform and the truck should sit level. Look for cracked or welded spring hangers; rust at the spring mounts is an MOT failure in the UK.
- [ ] **Engine health**
  Low knocking points to worn crank bearings; a lighter, rapid tapping may just be tappets needing adjustment. Occasional blue smoke can be valve-stem seals, continuous blue smoke means rings and bores, and black smoke points at the carburettor.
- [ ] **Wheels and tyres**
  Original Series rims are tube-type. Tubeless radials need wheels with safety humps (later Defender-style wheels), and you shouldn't run tubes in tubeless wheels. Check what's fitted before you assume the tyres are a simple swap.

YEARS TO KNOW

1961	SWEET SPOT	Series IIA: 2.25 diesel; 2.6 six in the 109 from 1967. Classic Car Hub calls an 88 or 109 IIA the sweet spot of the Series range

1971	SWEET SPOT	Series III: all-synchro gearbox, plastic grille and new dash. Octane calls it by far the easiest Series to live with and suggests a short-wheelbase 2.25 petrol

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Chassis number (pre-1979)**
  Stamped on an aluminium plate, on the bulkhead inside the cab on earlier trucks and under the bonnet on later ones. The first three digits give model, body and engine: 241–245 is a IIA 88 petrol, 251–255 a IIA 109 petrol, 901–905 a Series III 88 petrol, 911–915 a Series III 109 petrol.
- ☐ **17-character VIN (late 1979 on)**
  Land Rover switched to 17-character VINs at the end of 1979. Glencoyne's examples: LBCAH... is a Series III 109 petrol, LBAAG... a Series III 88 diesel.
- ☐ **Which Series is it?**
  Series I (1948–58) has flat sides. Series II (1958–61) has the wider barrel-side body. IIA (1961–71) looks almost the same, and late home-market IIAs have headlamps in the wings. Series III (1971–85) has a plastic grille and a plastic dash with instruments in front of the driver.
- ☐ **NADA trucks and licence-builds**
  Only 811 long-wheelbase 2.6 six IIAs were NADA (North American Dollar Area) trucks. Bring a Trailer also sells many Spanish-built Santana and Colombian 'Ensambladora Automotriz' 88s and 109s, so confirm the maker.
- ☐ **Heritage certificate**
  The British Motor Museum's Heritage Certificates cover Land Rovers from 1948 on and copy the factory ledger: build and despatch dates, engine number, colour and equipment.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/land-rover/series/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks